

Throughout my coursework, my understanding of cultural competence has grown centered on identity, cultural humility, biases, and responsive practice. Throughout my classes and research assignments, I have been able to recognize my biases along with the importance of being culturally competent. Reflecting back, I had very little knowledge of other cultures, cultural backgrounds, and challenges. However, my research on cultural competence with Arab-American populations challenged me to learn more on individuals identity, religion, and experiences in the States. I am now able to acknowledge the importance of my role as a counselor to be culturally aware and actively advocating for minorities.

My journey toward reflecting on my personal biases and decolonizing my approach has been a continuous journey. Through studying decolonizing research, I realized that my education has been shaped by systems that often prioritize Western ideologies while overlooking minorities. Learning that counseling theories have been around for many years but within indigenous tribes was eye-opening. There were many practices being done throughout the years. However, society pushed traditional practices and implemented them by calling theories different names and prioritizing Western customs. This has encouraged me to reflect and acknowledge whose experiences are represented in counseling research and whose are missing. Many minority communities are often overlooked in this field due to the stigma that surrounds their background along with cultural differences from society. Because of this knowledge I have gained, I am more intentional in my work with clients when they come from a different cultural background. Rather than assuming traditional clinical models apply to everyone, I make a conscious effort to recognize clients as the experts on their own cultural backgrounds and lived experiences.